



Pipers play spoilsport

A rampant Triveni Continental Kings was on its way to a hat-trick of titles, but Alpine SG Pipers had **other ideas** in the final.

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Mumbai's Royal Opera House was packed on December 23. On a stage that has showcased some of the finest talent in music and theatre for over a century, some of the world's best chess players were battling it out for the Global Chess League trophy.

This was the first time the league, a joint venture between Tech Mahindra and FIDE, was being staged in India. The first two seasons were held in Dubai and London, with Triveni Continental Kings winning both editions and establishing themselves as the benchmark team in this franchise-based competition.

This time all six teams in the league were evenly matched, and any side could have emerged champion. Triveni Continental Kings

was the most dominant team during the league phase, qualifying for the final with a round to spare.

Alpine SG Pipers (**above**), on the other hand, made it through with just one more game point than Ganges Grandmasters.

In the end, the Pipers won the final, beating the Kings rather convincingly. The GCL finally had a new champion — a side coached by Mumbai's own Pravin Thipsay, India's third Grandmaster. "This is the happiest moment of my life," he told *Sportstar* shortly after his team won both matches in the final (a draw in the second would have sufficed).

With a line-up featuring Fabiano Caruana, Anish Giri, R. Praggnanandhaa, Hou Yifan, Nino Batsiashvili and Leon Mendonca, it was clear that he had assembled the right team at the auction.